

Sub 4:00 Marathon Plan

An 18-week, 6-block plan built for runners ready to run their first marathon under 4 hours — or finally break that barrier after coming close. Target pace: 8:25–8:35/mile. Everything you need from week one through race day. Target pace: 8:25–8:35/mile. Everything you need from week one through race day.

Sub 4:00	8:30	18	6
TARGET FINISH	TARGET PACE/MI	WEEK PROGRAM	TRAINING BLOCKS

WHO THIS IS FOR

Your first sub-4. Built to get you there.

This plan is for runners who are ready to run their first marathon under 4 hours — or who have tried and want to finally break the barrier. It's serious, structured, and built to get you to the finish line in under 4 hours.

18 weeks. 6 distinct training blocks. Each with a specific purpose — building your base, raising your threshold, sharpening race pace, peaking, tapering, and executing. You don't need to have run a marathon before. You need to be willing to do the work.

— Marathon base required

You should be running 25–30 miles per week comfortably before starting. This plan is built for serious first-timers and experienced runners chasing sub-4 for the first time.

— Target finish time

Sub-4:00. Target race pace is 8:25–8:35 per mile throughout the plan.

— Time commitment

5–6 days per week. Mileage peaks at 55–60 miles per week in Block 4. Strength work is integrated.

— Recovery is part of the plan

Recovery days, deload weeks, and taper phases are not optional. They are where the fitness is built.

THE 6-BLOCK STRUCTURE

18 weeks broken into 6 purpose-built phases.

BLOCK 1

Weeks 1–4

Base Building

Build weekly mileage to 30–40 miles. Establish aerobic base. Introduce speed with strides, fartlek, and light tempo. Build routine and durability.

BLOCK 2

Weeks 5–8

Mileage Build

Raise weekly mileage to 35–46 miles. Increase threshold and aerobic volume. Introduce marathon pace blocks. Midweek longer runs for durability.

BLOCK 3

Weeks 9–12

Race Pace & Efficiency

Improve comfort at marathon pace. Build fatigue resistance. Simulate race demands through sustained MP efforts. Long runs peak at 18 miles.

BLOCK 4

Weeks 13–15

Peak Training

Peak weekly mileage 50–60 miles. Final long runs with MP finishes. 20-mile peak long run. Push the mental edge of your fitness.

BLOCK 5

Weeks 16–17

Taper Phase

Reduce mileage 20–40%. Maintain speed and MP efficiency. Let legs fully recover. Build mental focus and trust in your training.

BLOCK 6

Week 18

Race Week

Maximize recovery. Keep legs sharp with short easy efforts. Finalize gear, nutrition, pacing. Trust the process. Race day: Chicago Marathon.

Block 1

Target mileage: 30–42 miles/week

Build weekly mileage gradually. Establish strong aerobic base. Begin speed development with strides, fartlek, and light tempo. Build durability and routine.

Week 1

BASE BUILDING

Goal: Establish routine. Reintroduce structured training.

DAY	WORKOUT	STRENGTH / NOTES
Mon	4–5 mi easy + 4x20s strides + optional core	Light core work — posture + form
Tue	Tempo: 3 mi @ 8:00–8:15 + WU/CD (~6 mi)	
Wed	6 mi steady @ 9:00–9:20/mi	
Thu	3 mi recovery jog + 4x20s strides OR Rest	
Fri	Fartlek: 6x1 min fast (7:15–7:30) w/ 90s jog + easy miles (~5 mi)	
Sat	3–4 mi easy jog + mobility OR OFF	
Sun	8 mi long run @ 9:00–9:20/mi	

Week 2

BASE BUILDING

Goal: Increase volume slightly. Extend tempo effort.

DAY	WORKOUT	STRENGTH / NOTES
Mon	5 mi easy + 4x20s strides + core	Core continues to reinforce posture
Tue	4 mi continuous tempo @ 7:55–8:10 + WU/CD (~6.5 mi)	
Wed	6 mi steady aerobic	
Thu	Rest or 3 mi jog + strides	
Fri	Fartlek: 8x1 min fast w/ 1 min jog + WU/CD (~5–6 mi)	
Sat	3–4 mi easy OR OFF + mobility	
Sun	Long Run: 9 mi @ easy pace	

Week 3

BASE BUILDING

Goal: Continue mileage build. Introduce interval-style tempo.

DAY	WORKOUT	STRENGTH / NOTES
Mon	5 mi easy + 4x20s strides + core	
Tue	Workout: 2x2 mi @ 7:55–8:10 w/ 2 min jog + WU/CD (~7 mi)	

Wed	6–7 mi aerobic	
Thu	3–4 mi recovery OR full rest	
Fri	Hill Sprints: 8x20s hard uphill + 4 mi total	
Sat	3 mi easy jog OR mobility only	
Sun	Long Run: 10 mi @ 9:00–9:20/mi	

Week 4

BASE BUILDING

Goal: Round out block with progression run and longest long run yet.

DAY	WORKOUT	STRENGTH / NOTES
Mon	4–5 mi easy + strides + core	
Tue	Progression Run: 5 mi (Start @ 9:15, end @ 8:00) + WU/CD (~6.5 mi)	
Wed	7 mi steady	
Thu	3 mi jog + mobility OR rest	
Fri	Fartlek Ladder: 3-2-1-3-2-1 min fast w/ equal jog (~6 mi)	
Sat	3 mi easy OR full OFF	
Sun	Long Run: 11 mi easy	

Block 2

Target mileage: 33–46 miles/week

Raise weekly mileage to 35–46 miles. Increase threshold and aerobic volume. Introduce marathon pace blocks. Midweek longer runs for durability.

Week 5			MILEAGE BUILD
Goal: Introduce marathon pace work. Raise aerobic capacity.			
DAY	WORKOUT	STRENGTH / NOTES	
Mon	5–6 mi easy (smooth shakeout post-long run)	Heel Elevated Goblet Squat 3x10 / DB Reverse Lunge 3x8/leg / Lat Pull Down 3x12 / Single Arm DB Bench 3x10/side / Dead Bugs 3x8/side	
Tue	Tempo: 5 mi @ 7:55–8:10 + 1.5 mi WU/CD (~8 mi)		
Wed	6–7 mi steady aerobic	DB Step-Ups 3x8/leg / Single Leg RDLs 3x10/leg / Glute Bridge March 2x20 / Split Squat Iso Holds 2x30s / Banded Lateral Walk 3x15/side / Core: Side Planks 30s + Crunches 25	
Thu	3–4 mi easy or full rest		
Fri	Progression: 6 mi — Start @ 9:30, finish @ 7:45	DB Incline Press 3x10 / Single Arm Bend Row 3x12/each / Lateral DB Raise 2x15 / Push-Up to Renegade Row 3x10 / Russian Twist 2x15 / Hollow Hold 2x30sec	
Sat	2–3 mi super easy or full rest	(Optional) Planks 3x30sec / Plank Reach 3x15s/side / Hip 90/90 Rotations 2x10 / Walking Hamstring Stretch / Couch Stretch	
Sun	Long Run: 12 mi — last 2 mi @ 8:30ish		

Week 6			MILEAGE BUILD
Goal: Extend time at threshold. Practice finishing strong.			
DAY	WORKOUT	STRENGTH / NOTES	
Mon	5 mi easy (recovery run, super slow)	Heel Elevated Goblet Squat 3x10 / DB Reverse Lunge 3x8/leg / Lat Pull Down 3x12 / Single Arm DB Bench 3x10/side / Dead Bugs 3x8/side	
Tue	Cruise Intervals: 4x1 mile @ 7:45–8:00		
Wed	7–8 mi aerobic	DB Step-Ups 3x8/leg / Single Leg RDLs 3x10/leg / Glute Bridge March 2x20 / Split Squat Iso Holds 2x30s / Banded Lateral Walk 3x15/side / Core: Side Planks 30s + Crunches 25	
Thu	2–4 mi easy recovery or full rest		

Fri	Speed: 10x2 min (1 min faster than MP / 1 min recovery)	DB Incline Press 3x10 / Single Arm Bend Row 3x12/each / Lateral DB Raise 2x15 / Push-Up to Renegade Row 3x10 / Russian Twist 2x15 / Hollow Hold 2x30sec
Sat	2–3 mi super easy or full rest	(Optional) Planks 3x30sec / Plank Reach 3x15s/side / Hip 90/90 Rotations 2x10 / Walking Hamstring Stretch / Couch Stretch
Sun	Long Run: 13 mi — last 3 @ 8:20ish	

Week 7

Goal: Peak mileage. Longest long run yet.

MILEAGE BUILD

DAY	WORKOUT	STRENGTH / NOTES
Mon	6 mi easy (recover post long run)	Heel Elevated Goblet Squat 3x10 / DB Reverse Lunge 3x8/leg / Lat Pull Down 3x12 / Single Arm DB Bench 3x10/side / Dead Bugs 3x8/side
Tue	Threshold Intervals: 2x3 miles @ 8:00–8:10 w/ 2–3 min recovery	
Wed	8 mi steady aerobic	DB Step-Ups 3x8/leg / Single Leg RDLs 3x10/leg / Glute Bridge March 2x20 / Split Squat Iso Holds 2x30s / Banded Lateral Walk 3x15/side / Core: Side Planks 30s + Crunches 25
Thu	3 mi recovery or full rest	
Fri	Progression Tempo: 6 mi — Start @ 8:45, work down to 7:45	DB Incline Press 3x10 / Single Arm Bend Row 3x12/each / Lateral DB Raise 2x15 / Push-Up to Renegade Row 3x10 / Russian Twist 2x15 / Hollow Hold 2x30sec
Sat	2–3 mi super easy or full rest	(Optional) Planks 3x30sec / Plank Reach 3x15s/side / Hip 90/90 Rotations 2x10 / Walking Hamstring Stretch / Couch Stretch
Sun	Long Run: 14 mi — last 4 @ marathon pace	

Week 8

Goal: Slight drop in volume to absorb peak training.

MILEAGE BUILD

DAY	WORKOUT	STRENGTH / NOTES
Mon	4–5 mi easy (deload start to week)	Heel Elevated Goblet Squat 3x10 / DB Reverse Lunge 3x8/leg / Lat Pull Down 3x12 / Single Arm DB Bench 3x10/side / Dead Bugs 3x8/side
Tue	Tempo Intervals: 3x2 miles @ 7:55–8:15 w/ 2 min easy between	
Wed	6 mi aerobic	DB Step-Ups 3x8/leg / Single Leg RDLs 3x10/leg / Glute Bridge March 2x20 / Split Squat Iso Holds 2x30s / Banded Lateral Walk 3x15/side / Core: Side Planks 30s + Crunches 25
Thu	2–3 mi easy or full rest	

Fri	Speed Ladder: 5-4-3-2-1 min pickups w/ equal easy pace	DB Incline Press 3x10 / Single Arm Bend Row 3x12/each / Lateral DB Raise 2x15 / Push-Up to Renegade Row 3x10 / Russian Twist 2x15 / Hollow Hold 2x30sec
Sat	3 mi easy	(Optional) Planks 3x30sec / Plank Reach 3x15s/side / Hip 90/90 Rotations 2x10 / Walking Hamstring Stretch / Couch Stretch
Sun	Long Run: 12 mi — last 3 @ marathon pace	

Block 3

Target mileage: 48–58 miles/week

Improve comfort and control at marathon pace. Build fatigue resistance. Simulate real race demands through longer sustained efforts.

Week 9

RACE PACE & EFFICIENCY

Goal: Begin extended MP blocks. Test pacing control.

DAY	WORKOUT	STRENGTH / NOTES
Mon	5 mi easy + strides + core	
Tue	MP Workout: 3 mi WU → 5 mi @ MP → 2 mi CD (10 mi)	
Wed	7 mi steady aerobic	
Thu	OFF or 3–4 mi jog + mobility	
Fri	Fartlek: 6x2 min fast, 90s jog + strides (~5–6 mi)	
Sat	OFF or shakeout jog (2–3 mi easy)	
Sun	Long Run: 15 mi — last 5 mi @ marathon pace	

Week 10

RACE PACE & EFFICIENCY

Goal: Increase MP volume. Build long-run efficiency.

DAY	WORKOUT	STRENGTH / NOTES
Mon	5 mi easy + 4x20s strides	
Tue	Tempo: 2x3 mi @ 7:55–8:10 w/ 3 min jog rest (~8 mi)	
Wed	8 mi aerobic	
Thu	OFF or 4 mi recovery jog	
Fri	Progression: 6 mi (start @ 9:15 → finish @ 7:45)	
Sat	3 mi easy OR mobility session	
Sun	Long Run: 16 mi — last 6 mi @ marathon pace	

Week 11

RACE PACE & EFFICIENCY

Goal: Peak tempo fitness. Hold pace under fatigue.

DAY	WORKOUT	STRENGTH / NOTES
Mon	5–6 mi easy + strides	
Tue	Threshold Tempo: 4 mi @ 7:50–8:05 + WU/CD (~7 mi)	

Wed	8 mi aerobic	
Thu	OFF or 3–4 mi recovery	
Fri	8 mi steady w/ 3x1 mi @ MP inside	
Sat	3 mi easy jog OR rest	
Sun	Long Run: 17 mi — steady w/ fast finish last 3 mi @ 7:50–8:00	

Week 12

RACE PACE & EFFICIENCY

Goal: Simulate race week structure. Test fueling. Longest effort.

DAY	WORKOUT	STRENGTH / NOTES
Mon	5 mi easy + core + strides	
Tue	2x3 mi @ 8:00–8:10 w/ 3 min jog (~7–8 mi)	
Wed	6–7 mi aerobic	
Thu	OFF or 4 mi easy jog	
Fri	4 mi easy + strides	
Sat	OFF or 2 mi shakeout jog + mobility	
Sun	Long Run: 18 mi — last 6 mi @ marathon pace	

Block 4

Target mileage: 48–60 miles/week

Peak weekly mileage. Practice marathon pace under cumulative fatigue. Final long runs with strong MP finishes. Push the mental edge of your fitness.

Week 13

PEAK TRAINING

Goal: Simulate race fatigue with long MP workout and steady volume.

DAY	WORKOUT	STRENGTH / NOTES
Mon	5–6 mi easy + strides + core	
Tue	Workout: 2 mi WU → 6 mi @ MP → 2 mi CD (10 mi)	
Wed	8 mi aerobic	
Thu	OFF or 3–4 mi recovery jog	
Fri	Fartlek: 8x2 min fast w/ 90s jog + 2 mi easy (6 mi)	
Sat	3–4 mi easy OR OFF	
Sun	Long Run: 18 mi — last 6 mi @ marathon pace	

Week 14

PEAK TRAINING

Goal: Hit peak mileage. Simulate race week fatigue in your 20-miler.

DAY	WORKOUT	STRENGTH / NOTES
Mon	6 mi easy + strides	
Tue	3x2 mi @ 7:55–8:05 w/ 2 min jog (~8 mi)	
Wed	8–9 mi aerobic	
Thu	OFF or 3–4 mi recovery	
Fri	6 mi steady w/ 4x30s strides	
Sat	OFF or 2–3 mi shakeout jog	
Sun	Long Run: 20 mi — last 7 mi @ marathon pace	

Week 15

PEAK TRAINING

Goal: Back off volume slightly. Maintain intensity. Prepare for taper.

DAY	WORKOUT	STRENGTH / NOTES
Mon	5 mi easy + strides + core	
Tue	Progression: 5 mi (start @ 9:00 → finish @ 7:45)	

Wed	7–8 mi steady aerobic	
Thu	OFF or 3 mi jog	
Fri	MP Repeats: 3x2 mi @ 8:15 w/ 2 min jog (~7–8 mi)	
Sat	OFF or short shakeout jog	
Sun	Long Run: 16 mi — last 4–5 mi @ marathon pace	

Block 5

Target mileage: 32–44 miles/week

Reduce weekly mileage 20–40%. Maintain speed and MP efficiency. Let your legs fully recover. Build mental focus and trust in your training.

Week 16

TAPER

Goal: Begin taper with 20–25% mileage cut. Keep effort sharp.

DAY	WORKOUT	STRENGTH / NOTES
Mon	5 mi easy + strides + core	
Tue	Workout: 2x2 mi @ 8:10–8:20 w/ 3 min jog (~6–7 mi)	
Wed	5–6 mi aerobic	
Thu	OFF or 3 mi jog + mobility	
Fri	5 mi steady w/ 4x20s strides	
Sat	2–3 mi recovery jog OR OFF	
Sun	Long Run: 14 mi — last 3 mi @ marathon pace	

Week 17

TAPER

Goal: Cut volume again. Lock in final rhythm. Shift mentally into race mode.

DAY	WORKOUT	STRENGTH / NOTES
Mon	4 mi easy + core + strides	
Tue	Workout: 3x1 mi @ MP w/ 2 min jog (~5 mi)	
Wed	4–5 mi aerobic	
Thu	OFF or 3 mi shakeout jog	
Fri	4 mi easy w/ 4x20s strides	
Sat	OFF or light mobility + shakeout (1–2 mi)	
Sun	Long Run: 10 mi — last 2 mi @ marathon pace	

Block 6 · Week 18

RACE DAY: 26.2 MILES

Maximize recovery. Keep legs sharp with short, low-stress efforts. Finalize gear, nutrition, pacing plan. You're not building fitness — you're unleashing it.

Week 18

RACE WEEK

Goal: Enter race day with full physical and mental readiness.

DAY	WORKOUT	STRENGTH / NOTES
Mon	3 mi easy + 4x20s strides + light core	Shake off stiffness. Smooth and relaxed.
Tue	OFF or 2 mi jog + light mobility	Total rest is fine. Or move gently.
Wed	Workout: 2 mi WU → 2 mi @ MP → 1 mi CD (5 mi)	Final MP effort — feel confident and quick.
Thu	3 mi easy OR OFF	Listen to your legs. Rest if tired.
Fri	2–3 mi easy + 2x20s strides	Light and relaxed. Stay loose.
Sat	1–2 mi shakeout + gear check + stretching	Check your kit. Go through race plan mentally.
Sun	RACE DAY: 26.2 MILES Goal: Sub-4:00 (Target: 3:45–3:55)	8:25–8:35 pace. Start smooth. Fuel early. Crush the final 10K.

RACE DAY REMINDERS

- **Pacing Plan:** Start at 8:30–8:35/mi. Do not go out hot. Settle in for the first 3–5 miles. The race starts at mile 18.
- **Fueling:** Gel every 30–40 minutes + water at every aid station. Practice this in training.
- **Sleep:** Prioritize sleep Monday–Thursday of race week. Pre-race night sleep matters less than the week prior.
- **Gear:** No new shoes. Wear what's tested. Lay out your complete kit on Saturday.
- **Mindset:** You've done 18 weeks of focused work. You've earned this. Don't chase — execute.

A NOTE FROM COACH TYLER

Sub-4 is not just a time. It's who you decide to be.

Running a marathon under 4 hours for the first time is a line you only get to cross once. This plan builds you up to that moment deliberately — base, threshold, race pace, peak, taper, execute.

The athlete who used this plan to run sub-4 for the first time wasn't the most talented runner. He was the most consistent one. He showed up every week, did the work, and trusted the structure. That's all this takes.

If you want this plan built specifically around your fitness, your schedule, and your race — apply for 1-on-1 coaching. Every ARA athlete I've coached has hit a personal record.

APPLY FOR 1-ON-1 COACHING → alwaysreddyathletics.com

Always Reddy Athletics · alwaysreddyathletics.com · [@alwaysreddyathletics](https://www.instagram.com/alwaysreddyathletics)